

MIG-17

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-17

Age: 35

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Lebanon

Host country: Canada

Years in host country: 7

Occupation: Architect

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I immigrated to Canada seven years ago because of the economic collapse and the ongoing political instability in Lebanon, which had made building a professional future there feel impossible for someone in my position. As a trained architect, I could see no real prospects amid the deepening crisis, the currency collapse, the lack of work, the general breakdown, so I applied through the skilled worker programme in search of stability and opportunity. Canada offered the chance to actually practise my profession and to build a secure life, so I made the genuinely difficult choice to leave behind my beloved homeland, my family, and everything familiar. It was painful to go, but staying would have meant watching my career and my future erode along with the country itself, and I was not willing to accept that.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means that my professional expertise is respected regardless of my accent or my origins, that I am evaluated on the quality of my work and my ideas rather than on assumptions about where I come from. It shows itself when I can advance in my field without hidden barriers holding me back, and when my particular cultural background is seen as something that enriches my design perspective and brings valuable insight rather than as a limitation. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that I am a full participant in Canadian society, contributing my skills and helping to shape the communities and buildings around me, rather than being a perpetual outsider whose competence is always somehow in question or whose belonging is conditional.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: I have experienced subtle xenophobia more often than overt hostility, which can be harder to name but is wearing nonetheless. It shows up as assumptions about my capabilities, or as visible surprise when people learn about my qualifications and experience, as though a Middle Eastern woman could not be an accomplished architect. As someone from the Middle East, I occasionally face a kind of vague suspicion or encounter ignorant and hurtful comments about my region and its people. While Canada is generally welcoming and I do not want to overstate the difficulties, these microaggressions

accumulate and serve as a reminder that I am sometimes still viewed as an outsider despite my contributions, my citizenship, and my commitment to this country.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The main challenges were getting my architectural credentials recognised here, which required additional examinations and a licensing process that delayed my career and meant working below my level for a time, a frustrating and humbling experience. Adapting to Canadian building codes, professional standards, and workplace norms took time and effort as well. The cold climate was a genuine shock coming from the Mediterranean, something I found harder to adjust to than I had expected. And being so far from my family during Lebanon's ongoing crises, worrying about their safety and wellbeing from across the world while unable to help directly, has been emotionally very difficult to bear throughout my years here.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My architecture firm is professional and reasonably diverse, and my colleagues respect my work and treat me as a valued member of the team. Once I had proven my competence, which sometimes required proving it a little more thoroughly than others might have to, I was genuinely welcomed and entrusted with significant and interesting projects. The Canadian professional environment, while it occasionally requires someone like me to prove herself more than a native-born colleague might, has ultimately been fair and rewarding for my career and for the development of my skills. I feel that my work is seen and valued, which is what matters most to me professionally, and that has made a real difference.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain my Lebanese identity through our cuisine, which I love and cook often, through the language, through the music that reminds me of home, and through staying deeply connected to my family and to the wider Lebanese diaspora community here in Canada. At the same time, I have wholeheartedly embraced Canadian multiculturalism and its values, integrating comfortably and genuinely into the life of the country. I feel proudly Lebanese-Canadian, able to draw on both my rich Mediterranean heritage and my Canadian home to enrich my life and, interestingly, my architectural work, which is informed by both sensibilities. The two identities coexist naturally in me rather than competing, and I consider that a genuine gift.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Media portrayal of the Middle East focuses overwhelmingly and relentlessly on conflict, war, and instability, which inevitably colours how people perceive those of us who come from the region, so that we are associated in the public mind with turmoil and danger. People are sometimes visibly surprised to learn that I am an accomplished professional with a normal, peaceful life and career. More nuanced and balanced representation, showing the rich culture, the history, and the educated professionals and ordinary people who come from the Middle East, would help considerably to counter these persistent and limiting stereotypes that reduce a diverse and ancient region to nothing more than a site of perpetual conflict in the Western imagination.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Canada's settlement services were genuinely helpful with the initial orientation and the practical business of getting established, and there were professional bridging programmes that assisted with the credential recognition process, which I appreciated. The support was decent overall, better than what is available in many other countries, and I do not want to be ungrateful for it. However, the credential recognition process for skilled professionals like me could be considerably streamlined and made more efficient, because as things stand, many immigrants with valuable skills and training end up underemployed for extended periods while navigating lengthy and sometimes unnecessarily burdensome licensing requirements, which wastes both their potential and the country's opportunity to benefit from it.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I hope that any children I may have will embrace their Lebanese heritage while also thriving fully as Canadians in this multicultural society, holding both identities comfortably and with pride rather than experiencing them as a source of tension or division. I have watched other Lebanese-Canadian families raise confident, well-adjusted, bicultural children who succeed here and who honour their roots at the same time, which gives me real hope for what is possible. I want the next generation to carry forward our culture and our traditions proudly while fully enjoying the opportunities and the acceptance that Canada offers, so that they lose nothing of who they are even as they gain everything this country can give them.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, education about the genuine diversity and cultural richness of Middle Eastern societies is important, in order to counter the conflict-focused and one-dimensional media narratives that dominate. Streamlining the process of professional integration would help immigrants contribute fully and quickly, reducing the frustration and waste of underemployment. And personal relationships across cultures, which are common and encouraged in Canada's diverse cities, dissolve prejudice effectively, as they always do; when people come to know us as skilled colleagues, as capable professionals, and as neighbours and friends, the stereotypes they may have absorbed from the media naturally fade and are replaced by genuine, individual understanding and respect.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to advance to a leadership role within my firm and, in time, perhaps to design projects that meaningfully bridge my Lebanese and Canadian influences, bringing something of both traditions into my work. I want to mentor other immigrant professionals who face the same credential barriers and the same subtle prejudices that I encountered, easing their path. And looking further ahead, I dream of one day contributing to rebuilding efforts in Lebanon, using my architectural skills and my experience to help my homeland recover and flourish if and when circumstances allow, giving something back to the country that shaped me even as I build my life and career here.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to skilled immigrants is to persist patiently through the credential recognition process, because it is genuinely frustrating and slow but it is surmountable, and it is worth it to reach the level your training deserves. Network actively within your profession to build the relationships that lead to

opportunities. Be confident in your expertise even when you find yourself having to prove it more than you feel you should have to. Embrace the multicultural environment fully while honouring and maintaining your own roots and heritage. And connect with your diaspora community, because it offers both practical support and a comforting sense of belonging that sustains you as you build your new life.